

Ψ LM: Coupling Frozen Language and Physics Models through Trainable Latent Bridges

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Abstract

We ask whether a pretrained language model and a pretrained physics model can run as one system — two frozen networks answering a single question with communication carried entirely by hidden states, the way the brain’s hemispheres cooperate across the corpus callosum. As of August 2026 we find no published work coupling a pretrained LLM to a neural-operator physics model through a bidirectional latent channel at inference. We build such a system, Ψ LM, on a consumer laptop (Apple M2, 24 GB), in four steps. (1) Tool-loop baselines reproduce the known capability-gap effect: a simulator adds +28.3 points to a 3B model on physics QA but *hurts* a 0.5B model. (2) We produce, to our knowledge, the first public reproduction of the Bicameral Model [12]: two frozen Qwen2.5-0.5B streams coupled by a 6.2M-parameter gated hidden-state interface reproduce the paper’s phase transition, reaching 100% exact tool recall through the latent channel alone. (3) With the auxiliary language model replaced by a frozen Fourier Neural Operator, Ψ LM answers Burgers-equation field-value questions at 100% (tolerance ± 0.05 ; MAE 0.014) where the LLM alone achieves 5%, matching the accuracy of an oracle that states the answer in text — with no text at the interface. (4) The result survives hardening: held-out question families expose a clean generalization law (*support coverage* — readouts generalize only where their training support covers the test distribution, a hypothesis we confirm by refuting the alternative), and the architecture transfers to 2D reaction–diffusion with a pretrained physics foundation model (DPOT-Tiny) as the hemisphere, scoring 95%, within five points of the oracle ceiling. All experiments, including two failed designs and one refuted hypothesis, are reproducible from the public repository on a single consumer machine.

1 Introduction

Large language models reason in discrete tokens; physics foundation models [3, 16] evolve continuous fields. The human brain suggests a third architecture: specialized regions, neither subordinate to the other, co-processing a single task through dense internal communication. This paper takes the analogy literally. We couple a frozen pretrained LLM to a frozen pretrained physics model through small trainable *bridges* operating purely on hidden states — the language stream never sees the physics as text, and the physics model never parses a sentence — and ask whether the coupled system can answer questions neither component can answer alone.

A second motivation is epistemic. In the wave–particle picture of quantum mechanics, a discrete observation is one reading of an underlying continuous process; Bohr called the two descriptions *complementary*. Ψ LM instantiates that structure operationally: a continuous field evolved by a

*<https://github.com/ryoji-info/PsiLM>. **AI generation disclosure:** the research reported here was designed, implemented, executed, and written up by *Claude Fable 5* (Anthropic), working autonomously on the author’s Apple M2 laptop under the author’s direction; see Section 12.

neural operator, and a discrete verbal reading of it produced by a language model, with a learned interface deciding what crosses between them. The name is the wave function Ψ .

Our literature survey (Section 2) found the ingredients of such a system published separately — frozen-model latent bridges [2, 44], two LLMs coupled in hidden-state lockstep [12], LLM–simulator loops through text [20, 38], and brain-inspired shared workspaces [13, 37] — but no published coupling of a pretrained LLM to a neural-operator physics model through a bidirectional latent channel at inference, a gap independently noted as open by a survey of latent inter-model communication [22]. We fill it at small scale, on consumer hardware, with the following contributions:

1. **Baselines** (Sec. 4): a seeded physics-QA benchmark on which text-level tool coupling reproduces the published capability-gap effect (+28.3 points at 3B, −3.3 at 0.5B).
2. **A reproduction** (Sec. 5): the first public reimplementations of the Bicameral Model [12], confirming its training phase transition and its causal order, and documenting two facts the paper does not: an inference bootstrap required at the uncoupled prompt boundary, and a teacher-forced/rollout dissociation showing exposure bias dominates evaluation at this scale.
3. **Ψ LM** (Sec. 6): a frozen LLM and a frozen neural operator coupled through ~ 3.5 M trainable bridge parameters, reaching the oracle-text ceiling on 1D Burgers field-value QA (100% vs. 5% for the LLM alone).
4. **A generalization law** (Sec. 7): on held-out question families the interface transfers partially, failure is attributable to a single readout, and a controlled experiment refutes the natural “classify, don’t regress” fix — establishing *support coverage* as the operative principle.
5. **Foundation-model transfer** (Sec. 8): the architecture carries to 2D reaction–diffusion with pretrained DPOT-Tiny [16] as the physics hemisphere (95% vs. 6.7% alone).
6. **Scaling the language hemisphere** (Sec. 9): a backbone-agnostic parameterization and an MLX port carry the architecture to Qwen3-1.7B (93.3% vs. a 96.7% oracle) and to 4-bit backbones; a trained revision loop adds +16.7 points on the held-out combination family; and at Qwen3-8B a probe-by-probe failure analysis locates the scale-dependent failure in the learned attention pointer, not in the latent channel.

2 Related Work

Text- and tool-level coupling. Mind’s Eye [20] pioneered LLM reasoning grounded by a physics engine through prompt round-trips; RAP [15] framed reasoning as an agent conversing with a world model in text; Zephyrus [38] couples an LLM to numerical weather foundation models through code; SGA [24] alternates an LLM with differentiable simulation for scientific discovery; RIA [36] closes an LLM/world-model loop per decision step for driving. In all of these the physics side is a subroutine reached through text or code. Multiagent debate [9] couples multiple reasoner instances through exchanged messages; Cicero [10] combines a language model with a strategic-reasoning module through structured intents. Position papers argue that language, agent, and world models must interoperate [17, 18].

Latent-level coupling. Flamingo [1] and BLIP-2 [19] graft frozen perception onto frozen LLMs unidirectionally; CALM [2] cross-attends between two frozen LLMs’ layers; GATS [44] exchanges activations bidirectionally among frozen models at different rates. Socratic Models [41] made language itself the inter-model protocol; a fast-moving line replaces it with embeddings, activations,

or KV state [21, 27, 31, 33, 35, 39, 45]; DroidSpeak [23] shows even same-architecture models need repair to share raw state, motivating trained interfaces. Closest to our Stage 1, the Bicameral Model [12] runs two frozen LLMs in per-token lockstep through a trainable gated interface; no code was released.

Brain-inspired modular systems. The Global Workspace line [8, 13, 25, 37] couples frozen specialists through a learned shared latent space; bilateral architectures [30, 32] build literal two-hemisphere networks with an ablated callosal channel; Béna and Goodman [4] show module specialization requires a bandwidth-constrained channel. Dual-process agents [6, 7] and dual-system robot policies [5, 11] run a slow semantic model and a fast control model concurrently over latent interfaces.

Language and PDE operators. UPS [34] projects FNO features into a pretrained LLM’s token space; Unisolver [43] conditions a neural solver on frozen-LLM equation embeddings; ICON-LM [40] fine-tunes a GPT-2 into an operator learner; Text2PDE [42] generates rollouts from text; Negrini et al. [26] decode operator states into text within one purpose-trained network. Each realizes one direction, or fuses everything into a single network; none couples two *pretrained* models bidirectionally at inference.

3 Experimental Platform

All experiments run on one Apple M2 laptop with 24 GB unified memory. The language hemisphere is frozen Qwen2.5-0.5B-Instruct [28] (hereafter Qwen2.5-0.5B; fp16 on PyTorch MPS; 4-bit MLX quantizations for Stage 0; Section 9 substitutes larger Qwen3 backbones), staged so a forward pass can pause at any decoder layer, exchange state, and resume; the staged pass is bit-exact against the stock model. Ground truth for the PDE tasks (Sections 6–8) comes from spectral solvers with integrating-factor RK4 (dt-convergence $\leq 4 \times 10^{-11}$; analytic limits verified), never from the neural physics models; Stages 0–1 are scored against closed-form mechanics and exact arithmetic. Trained components are only the interfaces (2–7M parameters on the 0.5B backbone; 12.6M and 42M for the larger backbones of Section 9); training runs in resumable 500–1000-step chunks at 1.8–12 s/step depending on the backbone.

4 Stage 0: Text-Level Tool Coupling

We construct a seeded 60-item benchmark of rigid-body comparison questions (five scene types; one third are physics traps such as equal-mass free fall and complementary launch angles) scored against closed-form mechanics, and evaluate an *alone* arm against a *tool* arm in which the LLM extracts scene parameters as JSON, a simulator computes the outcome, and the result returns to the prompt [20]. Parameter extraction succeeds on 100% of items at both model sizes, yet coupling helps only the larger model: Qwen2.5-3B improves 38.3% $\rightarrow$ 66.7% (+28.3, matching Mind’s Eye’s published +27.9 zero-shot average), while Qwen2.5-0.5B *degrades* 35.0% $\rightarrow$ 31.7% — it cannot reliably compare two numbers handed to it in text. Evidence *use*, not extraction, is the bottleneck, motivating a trained interface that delivers evidence below the token level.

5 Stage 1: Reproducing the Bicameral Model

We reimplement the Bicameral Model [12] from its published specification: two frozen Qwen2.5-0.5B streams generate in lockstep; a trainable interface reads the primary’s residual stream at layer 10 and writes a gated update into the auxiliary at layer 10 (forward coupling), and symmetrically

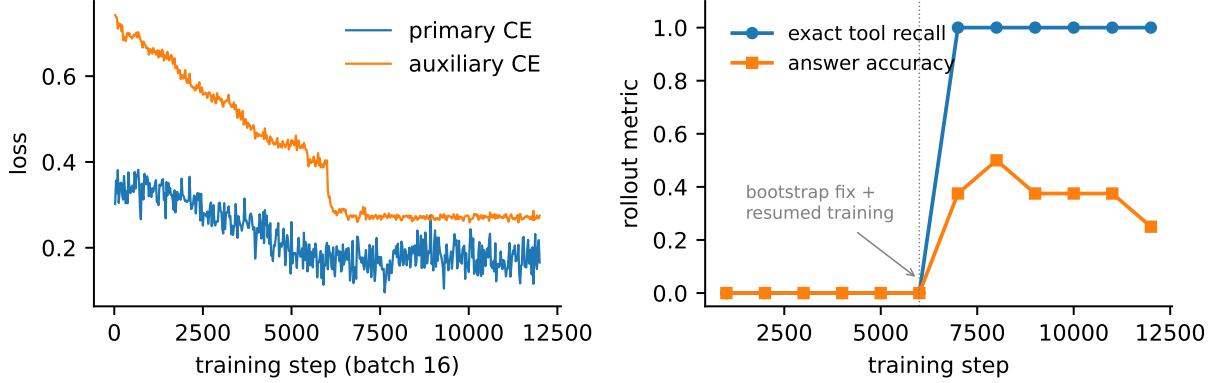


Figure 1: Stage 1 reproduction. **Left:** teacher-forced losses. **Right:** rollout metrics per 1000-step chunk. Exact tool recall undergoes the paper’s phase transition ($0 \rightarrow 1.00$ within one chunk, at $\sim 112k$ samples) after an inference-bootstrap fix at step 6000; answer accuracy sets in after recall, in the paper’s causal order.

auxiliary $\rightarrow$ primary at layer 15 (reverse), each update $h \leftarrow (1 - \sigma)h + \sigma f(h_{\text{send}})$ with the suppression gate σ computed from the *receiver*. The auxiliary drives a calculator whose output is forced into the auxiliary stream only; the primary receives results exclusively through the latent channel. We train the 6.2M-parameter interface with dual-target SFT on procedurally generated multiplication with causality-aligned auxiliary traces (192k samples).

The phase transition reproduces, in its causal order (Fig. 1): forward coupling strengthens first, exact tool recall then jumps $0.00 \rightarrow 1.00$ in a single chunk, and answer accuracy sets in afterward. On held-out problems (7–10-digit products) the coupled system emits the exact `calc(A*B)` on 100% of rollouts — the auxiliary reads the operands entirely from hidden states — while the reverse channel carries the leading 4–6 result digits reliably and degrades toward the tail (digit similarity 0.689 vs. 0.371 for the frozen model alone; exact match only 2.5% at this length, ~ 25 –50% on the shorter mixed-length products of the per-chunk rollout evaluations, $n=8$ each).

Two findings absent from the original paper: (i) the first auxiliary token is predicted from the *uncoupled* prompt tail, a position training can never influence, so free-running generation derails without a protocol-level bootstrap (we force two initial wait tokens); (ii) high teacher-forced channel quality coexists with zero rollout success until that bootstrap exists — exposure bias dominates evaluation at this scale (the committed diagnostic at the final checkpoint, `teacher_forced_diagnostic.json`: 100% call-token accuracy and 63.0% per-digit, against 0% rollouts before the bootstrap).

6 Ψ LM: A Language Model Coupled to a Neural Operator

Stage 2 replaces the auxiliary language model with a genuine physics model (Fig. 2). The task: “ $u(x, 0) = a \sin(2\pi x + \phi)$ evolves by Burgers’ equation ($\nu = 0.02$) until $t = 0.5$; what is u at x_0 ?” — answered to two decimals, scored within ± 0.05 on fields spanning ± 0.6 (a degenerate always-zero strategy scores 7.9% on the training distribution and 1.7% on the held-out set of Table 1). The physics hemisphere is a 70K-parameter FNO trained once on solver data to 0.28% relative error (one-shot $u_0 \mapsto u(\cdot, T)$, in the full-rollout style of contemporary physics foundation models) and then frozen.

Forward bridge (language $\rightarrow$ physics). Learned queries attention-pool the LLM’s layer-10

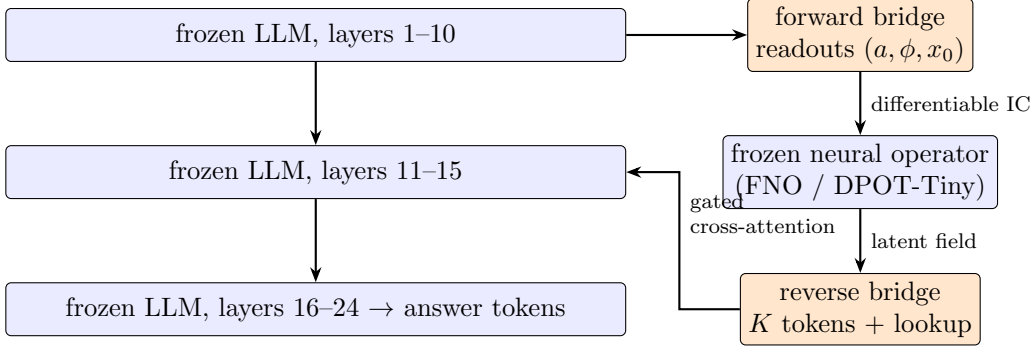


Figure 2: Ψ LM. Orange components (3.5–3.7M parameters) are the only trained ones. The question is read out of the LLM’s layer-10 hidden states; the frozen operator evolves the field; the result returns through a position-lookup token and gated cross-attention at layer 15. No text crosses the interface.

Table 1: Held-out results. Left: 1D Burgers ($n=60$). Right: 2D Fisher–KPP with pretrained DPOT-Tiny ($n=60$). Tolerance ± 0.05 ; greedy decoding; all arms share the frozen Qwen2.5-0.5B.

arm	1D Burgers (FNO)		2D Fisher–KPP (DPOT-Tiny)	
	acc@0.05	MAE	acc@0.05	MAE
LLM alone	5.0%	0.729	6.7%	0.337
LLM + answer in text (oracle)	100%	0.0028	100%	0.0024
ΨLM (latent coupling)	100%	0.0138	95.0%	0.0168
degenerate always-0.00	1.7%	0.308	1.7%	0.673

prompt states; heads regress $(a, \sin \phi, \cos \phi)$ and read the query position x_0 as a 100-way classification whose softmax expectation is differentiable and sharp. A differentiable sinusoid built from the readout feeds the operator, so answer-loss gradients flow from the LLM’s words into the physics input.

Reverse bridge (physics→language). $K=16$ learned queries compress the operator’s latent field (plus Fourier positional features and the predicted field itself) into soft tokens, joined by a *position-lookup token*: a periodic von Mises kernel of learnable sharpness, centered at the x_0 readout, samples the field “where the question asked,” with an auxiliary head deep-supervised on $u(x_0)$. All tokens enter the primary at layer 15 through gated cross-attention (receiver-computed suppression gate, near-closed initialization).

Training minimizes answer cross-entropy plus auxiliary readout losses (parameter MSE, x_0 CE, lookup-value MSE); both backbone networks stay frozen. Two design elements were forced by failure analysis, which we report as results: plain cross-attention over field summaries mode-collapsed to per-trajectory constants (the system answered the field’s *average* for every x_0), and a regressed x_0 (RMS error 0.06) was too blurry beside a shock; the classification pointer and the deep-supervised lookup cracked both: first-chunk rollout accuracy was 0.08 for both failed designs, then 0.50 and 1.00 in the final design’s first two 16k-sample chunks (Fig. 3 shows the final configurations).

Result (Table 1, left): Ψ LM answers 100% of held-out questions within tolerance (MAE 0.0138), matching the accuracy of an oracle that states the true value in the prompt — while the frozen LLM alone scores 5%. The answer travels entirely through hidden states: question out of the residual stream, simulation in the operator, value back through gated attention, verbalized by a frozen model.

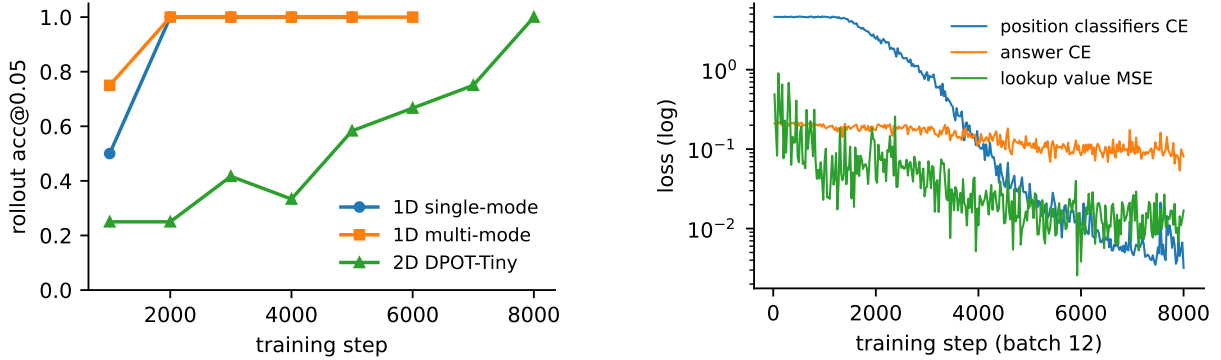


Figure 3: **Left:** rollout accuracy per training chunk for the three Ψ LM configurations. **Right:** 2D training phase structure — the four positional classifiers lock in first (over ~ 5 k steps); the answer loss converges only after the pointer does, echoing Stage 1’s causal ordering.

7 Generalization: the Support-Coverage Law

To harden the result we extend the initial conditions (ICs) to sums of sinusoids and train the bridges *only on single-mode questions*, evaluating on three families: in-distribution, the held-out combination (two-term questions never seen), and amplitude extrapolation beyond the training range. The physics FNO is trained on a broader distribution than any evaluation family, so transfer failures are attributable to the interface. Results ($n=48$ per family): in-distribution 97.9% (MAE 0.009); unseen combination 31.3% (0.128); extrapolation 50.0% (0.096) — all above the LLM-alone (0–6.3%) and always-zero (27.1%, 16.7%, 4.2%) baselines, decisively so except against the combination family’s zero baseline, and all far below in-distribution.

Teacher-forced attribution is unambiguous: the x_0 pointer generalizes *perfectly* to every family (absolute error $\leq 10^{-4}$), while the amplitude readout alone degrades $0.043 \rightarrow 0.355$ (combination) and 0.206 (extrapolation); the record is committed as `attribution.json`. The natural hypothesis — the classified quantity transfers, so classify the amplitudes too — we tested with a v2 interface (per-mode pooling queries; amplitudes as 121-bin classifications). **It was worse on every family** (extrapolation 50% $\rightarrow$ 19%, combination 31% $\rightarrow$ 21%; v2 was evaluated at its 64k-sample convergence plateau — rollout accuracy flat across its final two chunks — vs. v1’s 96k). The refutation identifies the real principle: x_0 generalized because all 100 of its bins occur in training, whereas amplitude bins outside the trained range never receive gradient and cannot move, while regression at least drifts. We summarize this as a *support-coverage law*: a trained latent interface generalizes like a learned model, not a program — coverage of the readout’s support at training time, not the readout’s parameterization, is what buys transfer. Section 8 applies the law prospectively.

8 2D Physics with a Pretrained Foundation Model

Finally we replace our own operator with DPOT-Tiny [16]: a 7.5M-parameter AFNO operator pretrained across twelve PDE datasets, loaded with `strict=True` from the published checkpoint, fine-tuned for 1200 steps (≈ 5 minutes) to 1.64% relative error on our task, then frozen. The task moves to 2D Fisher–KPP reaction–diffusion on the periodic unit square: a Gaussian bump — height, center, and width all stated in the question — grows and spreads by $u_t = D\nabla^2 u + r u(1 - u)$, and the question asks for u at a point (x_0, y_0) sampled within the front’s active zone (always-zero scores

4.8% on the training distribution; 1.7% held-out). The IC is replicated across DPOT’s 10-timestep input history; the reverse bridge attends over DPOT’s 256 latent patch tokens plus a separable 2D periodic lookup on the predicted field; applying the support-coverage law, we make every positional readout (bump center and query point) a fully covered 100-bin classification.

Training exhibits a clean phase structure (Fig. 3, right): the four positional classifiers lock in over ~ 5 k steps (CE $4.6 \rightarrow 0.04$), and the answer loss converges only after the 2D pointer does; rollout accuracy climbs $0.25 \rightarrow 1.00$ over 96k samples. Held-out (Table 1, right): **95.0%** at MAE 0.0168, within five points of the oracle-text ceiling, against 6.7% for the LLM alone. The 1D result survives both moves — to 2D, and to a physics hemisphere that is a genuine pretrained foundation model.

9 Scaling the Language Hemisphere

Stage 0 predicts that the payoff of coupling grows with the language model’s ability to *use* evidence. This section reports what happened when the language hemisphere was scaled from 0.5B to 1.7B and 8B parameters with the physics hemisphere (the Stage-2 FNO, byte-identical) and the task held fixed. The 1.7B result is a clean transfer. The 8B campaign is not yet one, and we report it as a scale-dependent failure analysis in the spirit of Sections 6 and 7: each step isolates one component, and the sequence ends in a decision, a concession, and an open result.

9.1 Backbone parameterization and Qwen3-1.7B

The interface is parameterized by the backbone’s configuration alone: coupling depths are the Stage-2 fractions of depth (read at 10/24, inject at 15/24, rounded), bridge widths follow the hidden size, and the staged forward pass is verified bit-exact against the stock model for every new backbone before training. On Qwen3-1.7B [29] (28 layers, hidden 2048; fp16 on PyTorch MPS; thinking mode disabled) the bridges resize to 12.6M parameters, couple at layers 12/18, and train at 5.2s/step. Under the Stage-2 budget (5000 steps $\times$ 16 = 80k samples) the per-chunk rollout probe reaches 1.00 in the fifth chunk, and the held-out evaluation ($n=60$, the set of Table 1) gives **93.3%** at MAE 0.022 against an oracle-text ceiling of 96.7% (MAE 0.021), with the LLM alone at 1.7% (MAE 2.57) and the always-zero strategy at 1.7%. Two observations. First, the receiver-computed gate, which settles at $\sigma \approx 0.13$ on the 0.5B, opens fully ($\sigma \rightarrow 1.0$) within the first 25 steps on the 1.7B and stays there: the stronger backbone takes the channel at full strength. Second, an evaluation-protocol lesson: the terse “reply with only the number” instruction that worked at 0.5B made Qwen3-1.7B’s non-thinking mode drop minus signs systematically (oracle 47%, half the negatives wrong, while free-form answers were correct). All text arms now use an “**Answer: <number>**” marker with marker-aware parsing, under which the coupled and oracle arms of Table 1 reproduce (100%/0.0138 and 100%).

9.2 Loop coupling: revision buys composition

Before scaling the backbone we asked whether the interface itself had headroom on the Section 7 families. `loop_model.py` runs two read $\rightarrow$ rollout $\rightarrow$ inject passes ordered $r_1 < w_1 < r_2 < w_2$ (layers 8/11, then 15/18 of 24), so the second readout sees the stream *after* the first injection and can revise it; the bridges are shared across passes (a recurrence), every pass’s readouts are supervised, and the answer loss is applied once. Table 2 compares it with the single-pass interface at a matched 96k-sample budget, plus a third arm that simply runs the single-pass-trained bridges as two passes at inference. **The trained loop buys compositional generalization:** +16.7 points on the unseen combination family, with MAE improved on every family (the extrapolation error nearly halves at flat accuracy — support coverage still rules there). The third arm collapses: switching

Table 2: Loop-coupling ablation on the multi-mode task of Section 7 (Ψ LM arm; $n=48$ per family; acc@0.05 / MAE; both trained arms at 96k samples).

family	single pass	loop-trained	inference-only loop
in-distribution	97.9% / 0.009	100% / 0.007	8.3% / 0.323
unseen combination	31.3% / 0.128	47.9% / 0.089	0.0% / 0.868
amplitude extrapolation	50.0% / 0.096	47.9% / 0.055	6.3% / 0.416

the loop on at run time without training it is catastrophic, not neutral, with the caveat that this arm changes the coupling depths and the untrained revision at once, so it bounds the zero-shot transplant rather than isolating the revision effect. Loops must be trained in; they then pay off exactly where the single-pass interface was weakest.

9.3 The MLX port

Backbones beyond ~ 2 B do not fit 24GB in fp16; their 4-bit quantizations do, so we ported the machinery to MLX [14]. The port (`psilm/mlx/`) is a segmented forward over `mlx-lm` models with explicit causal and padding masks, bit-exact against the stock model on the 4-bit Qwen2.5-0.5B (maximum logit difference 0.0, greedy tokens identical); an FNO port carrying the complex spectral weights as (real, imaginary) pairs, converted exactly from the trained PyTorch checkpoint (field difference 10^{-7}); and fp32 bridges trained by `nn.value_and_grad` through the frozen quantized backbone. Validation on the 4-bit 0.5B under the identical task and budget: per-chunk rollouts reach 1.00 at MAE 0.0136 by step 5000 ($n=12$ probe), against the fp16 run’s 1.00/0.0138 — the bridges absorb the backbone’s quantization noise — at 1.9s/step against 2.3 for fp16 PyTorch.

9.4 Qwen3-8B: a scale-dependent failure analysis

Qwen3-8B-4bit (36 layers, hidden 4096) is the largest dense backbone that trains on this machine (12s/step at batch 8; bridges 42.0M, most of it the 4096×4096 pooling keys). Its staged forward passes the parity test. What did not carry over was training, and the failure moved as we fixed it. We summarize five runs; runs 1–4 are recorded in the commit history, run 5 in `results/stage2_mlx8b4/`.

Saturation. At 4096 dimensions the raw residual-stream magnitudes saturated the bridges’ pooling softmax and gates: the x_0 classifier sat exactly at uniform cross-entropy ($\ln 100 = 4.61$) for 8k samples while the gate drifted to $\sigma = 0.86$ — no gradient reached the pointer (the very first unclipped setup steps had produced losses of 56 and 362). The fix is to make the interface scale-free: parameter-free RMS normalization of every bridge *input* (pooling, gate, and injection queries; the residual stream itself is untouched), and an injection scaled by the receiver’s local stream magnitude, $h \leftarrow h + \sigma \text{RMS}(h) f(\cdot)$.

Flatness, then a closed gate. RMS normalization traded saturation for flatness: the learned x_0 pool now averaged the whole prompt, and the classifier sat at uniform CE for a full 2500-step run while the parameter readout and the gate were healthy — the pointer was starved, not the channel. Supervising the pool’s attention mass on the x_0 token span (which the QA builder can compute exactly, since it wrote the prompt) moved that mass from 6% to 98.5% in six steps, and in the following run the pointer, parameters, and lookup all trained (pointer error 0.014; lookup MSE 0.001) — yet rollouts stayed at 0–25% and the gate closed ($0.12 \rightarrow 0.065$). The mechanism is specific to strong backbones: their answer cross-entropy starts at its digit-entropy floor because the format tokens are already solved, so early injection is pure noise, the receiver-computed gate suppresses it, and the channel never receives gradient. Digit-weighted CE ($\times 5$ on digit tokens),

Table 3: Copy probe: a random value $v \sim U(-1, 1)$ injected through the gated cross-attention alone (see text). 600 steps $\times$ batch 8; greedy rollouts, $n=24$, tolerance ± 0.05 ; σ is the mean gate at the end of training.

backbone (4-bit)	layers / width	inject at	bridge	s/step	final σ	acc@0.05	MAE
Qwen2.5-0.5B	24 / 896	15	1.49M	0.36	0.096	100%	0.0075
Qwen3-8B	36 / 4096	22	8.41M	5.55	0.042	91.7%	0.025

Table 4: Readout probe: the forward readout in isolation, trained only to classify x_0 into 100 bins from the RMS-normalized prompt states at the coupling layer (10/24 for the 0.5B, 15/36 for the 8B). Held-out exact-bin accuracy and mean absolute error ($n=48$); a uniform-random guess scores ≈ 0.33 on the error. *span* = parameter-free mean over the builder’s x_0 token span (oracle pooling).

backbone (4-bit)	pooling	steps $\times$ batch	exact bin	$ \hat{x}_0 - x_0 $
Qwen2.5-0.5B	learned query	400×8	2.1%	0.328
Qwen2.5-0.5B	span	400×8	18.8%	0.064
Qwen3-8B	learned query	400×8	2.1%	0.247
Qwen3-8B	learned query + attention supervision	400×8	2.1%	0.274
Qwen3-8B	final prompt position	400×8	0.0%	0.378
Qwen3-8B	span	400×8	2.1%	0.099
Qwen3-8B	learned query	2000×16	0.0%	0.284
Qwen3-8B	span	2000×16	83.3%	0.0046

an open gate initialization ($\sigma_0 = 0.5$), and injection at 75% depth (layer 27) did not rescue the fourth run. Two hypotheses were then live: (H1) large frozen backbones resist latent steering — the *channel* is the problem; (H2) the forward *readout* is the problem. We separated them with two probes.

Copy probe (H1). The minimal coupling task: v is encoded by a small MLP into eight soft tokens and injected through the same gated cross-attention into a prompt (“What is the secret number?”) that carries no information, so the only route from v to the answer is the channel. Table 3: the 8B verbalizes the injected number at 92% (MAE 0.025) after 600 steps, about 55 minutes, against 100% for the 0.5B — and does so with a gate of $\sigma = 0.04$. **H1 is false**, and the low gate values seen throughout were never suppression: 0.04 is the scale at which a 4096-dimensional stream wants the signal.

Readout probe (H2). We then isolated the forward readout — no physics, no injection, no answer loss — training only a pooled readout over the coupling-layer prompt states to classify x_0 (Table 4), with four ways of pooling: the learned query of the current design; the same plus attention-mass supervision; the final prompt position alone; and *span pooling*, a parameter-free mean over the builder’s x_0 token span, i.e. the pooling an oracle pointer would produce. At the short budget the ordering is already clear — span $\gg$ learned $>$ final position, the last at chance, so neither model aggregates x_0 into its final prompt position and pooling over the span is necessary — but the 100-way classifier is under-powered there: the 0.5B’s learned-query row, 2% exact here, is the same pointer that reaches 100% end-to-end in Section 6. At five times the budget the picture is unambiguous. **The learned pointer never leaves uniform at 8B:** its cross-entropy stays between 4.58 and 4.63, i.e. $\ln 100$, for all 2000 steps (0% exact), while span pooling over the identical hidden states reaches 83% exact-bin accuracy at error 0.0046. The information is present at the x_0 positions and readable by a two-layer head; learning *where to look* is what fails at this width, and it

does not fail slowly — it fails at every budget we could afford.

Decision, and its cost. The readout therefore pools deterministically over the builder’s span (the learned path remains as the fallback when no span is supplied). This is a real concession and we state it plainly: the builder knows where x_0 is because it wrote the prompt, so at 8B the language→physics *pointer* is supplied by the task rather than learned from the words, and a free-text question would have no such span.¹ What remains learned on the forward side is the readout of the value at those positions; on the reverse side, everything. Deterministic where the task permits, learned where it must be — the same principle as the position-lookup token of Section 6, applied one level further down.

Run 5. With span pooling, per-module gradient clipping (each bridge clipped at 1.0 separately, so the 4096-dimensional injection gradient cannot consume the global budget — the regime in which the probe converged), and the x_0 loss weight raised from 0.3 to 1.0 after the first chunk, the system trained for 2500 steps at batch 8: 20k samples, a quarter of the 0.5B budget. The parameter readout converged in the first chunk (MSE 0.46 → 0.02) and the digit-weighted answer loss fell from 0.40 to 0.33, but the x_0 head stayed at CE 2.1–3.4 (pointer error 0.04–0.20) where the probe, with the identical head, pooling, and backbone, had reached 0.74 at 32k samples; and the gate fell from its open initialization to 0.29 by the end of chunk 1, to 0.11 by chunk 2, and to 0.03–0.04 from step ~1100 onward, never reopening. Per-chunk held-out rollouts ($n=12$): 25%, 58%, 33%, 58%, **67%** (MAE 0.387, 0.108, 0.132, 0.074, 0.167). On the four-arm held-out evaluation ($n=60$; `results/stage2_mlx8b4/final_eval_summary.json`) the coupled system reaches **41.7%** (MAE 0.183) against 6.7% (MAE 0.706) for the backbone alone and 100% (MAE 0.0026) for the oracle — a six-fold gain over the uncoupled model on an eight-billion-parameter frozen backbone, and the first 8B run that learned end to end, but well short of the 0.5B and 1.7B systems, which close to within three points of their oracles. (The text arms of an 8B need a 768-token budget: Qwen3-8B writes a derivation before its **Answer:** line, and at 160 tokens every item truncated; even at 768, only 35% of the uncoupled model’s replies reach the line, against 100% for the oracle and for Ψ LM.)

Two causes, found by code review after the run and quantified against its log, are removed in the sixth run (in progress at submission; its trainer is committed): the optimizer state is now persisted across chunks with bias correction on, the pointer is detached on its way into the reverse bridge, and a readout-only warm-up phase locks the pointer before the channel first opens, so the gate never meets a wrong lookup. (i) The MLX trainer builds a fresh AdamW at every 500-step resume and, with the library’s default of no bias correction, the first ~15 steps after each resume take effectively 2–4× larger steps; both gate collapses in the log (0.29 → 0.25 at step 525, 0.11 → 0.05 at 1025) and the answer-loss spike (0.34 → 0.58 at step 1025) coincide with resumes, though the first boundary also changed the clipping and the loss weight. The PyTorch trainer persists optimizer state. (ii) The x_0 estimate feeds the reverse bridge’s lookup kernel without a stop-gradient, so the pointer head also receives lookup and answer gradients — near-orthogonal to its own cross-entropy gradient and about 0.4× its norm at initialization — the one structural difference from the probe, in which the same head converged three times faster. Budget is the confound behind both: the 1.7B needed its full 80k samples to reach 1.00 rollouts, and the 8B has seen a quarter of that.

Mixture-of-experts verdict. The natural next backbone on 24 GB is a sparse one. Qwen3-30B-A3B-4bit [29] (48 layers, hidden 2048, 128 experts, 8 active) loads in 17.2 GB and trains at a 19.8 GB peak, and the staged forward is bit-exact through its MoE blocks. One blocker had to be fixed: `mlx-lm`’s MoE block feeds the router’s `argpartition` indices straight into the expert gather, so autograd raises on the vector–Jacobian product; `moe_patch.py` wraps the routing indices

¹The span is found by a token-sublist match on the last number in the prompt, widened by one token on each side; on a failed match the builder falls back, silently, to pooling the whole prompt. The fallback never triggered on the present data, but it should raise rather than degrade.

in `stop_gradient`, which is also the mathematically correct statement (discrete selections carry no gradient; the router’s softmax scores and the expert paths still do), with parity unchanged. The verdict is on cost: 97.8s/step at batch 4 — roughly 24s per sample against 1.5 for the dense 8B — because sparsity saves FLOPs, not the gather/scatter dispatch that dominates on Metal. A MoE backbone is feasible here but not economical, and dense 8B remains the scaling vehicle. We note one measurement it uniquely affords: with untrained bridges, the injection already changes the top-8 expert selection at 9.3% of positions at the coupling layer, so routing steering by the physics hemisphere is directly observable.

What the campaign established. The architecture transfers to 1.7B within three points of its oracle, and a trained revision loop extends what the 0.5B interface can compose. At 8B the latent channel works (copy probe), the readout’s content is present and linearly readable (span probe), and the learned attention pointer is dead at any budget — a scale-dependent failure of *optimization*, not of capacity or of the frozen model’s willingness to be steered. Three interface changes survive from the campaign as general lessons: scale-free bridges, digit-weighted answer loss for backbones that have already solved the format, and deterministic pointers wherever the task can supply them. Whether the 8B system closes the remaining gap end-to-end is the open result above.

10 Discussion and Limitations

What has been shown. A frozen 0.5B language model and frozen partner models of three kinds (a twin LLM driving a calculator; a purpose-trained FNO; pretrained DPOT-Tiny) can be composed into systems that answer questions none of the parts can answer, with all inter-model traffic in latent space and only 2–7M trained parameters. At this scale the latent channel matches text-level oracle accuracy; its digit-level fidelity (Stage 1’s long products) is bounded by interface capacity and training budget, consistent with Flamant et al. [12].

What has not been shown. The forward readouts are parametric: the interface extracts a fixed set of quantities the task designer chose, and Section 7 shows transfer beyond their trained support is partial. General language-to-field translation — arbitrary ICs described in free text — remains open. Scaling the language side (Section 9) reaches 1.7B cleanly but, at 8B, only by supplying the pointer from the task, and its end-to-end result there is pending: where Stage 0 predicts larger gains in evidence use, we have so far measured larger *costs* in interface optimization. Our tasks are also ones where the oracle-text arm saturates; the deeper promise of latent coupling — carrying information that does not survive verbalization, at bandwidth text cannot match — is precisely what these tasks cannot yet measure. The brain analogy and the complementarity framing are motivations, not claims; likewise the author’s broader conjecture that grounding language models in physical law may support alignment is a direction for argument, not something these experiments establish.

Why small-scale results matter here. Every mechanism-level finding in this paper — the capability-gap reversal, the phase transitions and their causal order, the exposure-bias bootstrap, the mode collapse of unpointed attention, the support-coverage law — was discovered by failure analysis cheap enough to run on a laptop, and each transferred forward to the next, more capable configuration. The same interfaces are, by construction, what a frontier-scale coupling would train.

11 Reproducibility

Everything runs on one Apple M2 (24 GB). The repository <https://github.com/ryoji-info/PsiLM> contains all code, seeded data generators, committed QA datasets, training logs, and evaluation

records, including the failed designs; each stage reproduces with two or three commands documented in the README. Total training compute across all experiments is roughly 30 hours of Apple-silicon time.

12 AI Generation Disclosure

This work was generated by **Claude Fable 5** (Anthropic), operating as an autonomous research agent within Claude Code on the author’s laptop between August 28 and 30, 2026, under the author’s direction and review. Fable 5 performed the literature survey, proposed and implemented all architectures, ran and monitored all training, diagnosed the failures, formulated and refuted the intermediate hypotheses, and wrote this manuscript, including this section. The human author set the research question, the guiding analogies, the hardware constraint, and the project’s name, approved each stage, and bears responsibility for the published claims. All quantitative results are taken directly from committed experimental logs in the repository; the bibliography contains only works surfaced and verified during the project’s literature searches.

Acknowledgments

The Stage 1 design follows the published specification of Flamant et al. [12]; DPOT-Tiny is due to Hao et al. [16] (Apache-2.0). This project was conducted independently on consumer hardware.

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